and the outstanding bowler in our boyhood games of garden cricket, was in our side, still swinging the ball after all these years. I remember how, in a pool match against the Sparkport Delta club team from Durban, he bowled three perfect away-swingers to Dale Benkenstein and then clean bowled him with an in-swinger. We had a strong team and won the title in 2003, beating the University of Port Elizabeth in the final.

The telephone was ringing yet again.

And, again, it was Dave Nosworthy.

'AB,' he said, 'we'd like to offer you a Northerns contract for the 2003/04 season.'

It was a junior contract, worth R5 000 per month for six months. I was thrilled and contacted my uncle Chris, my mother's brother-in-law, because he was a radiologist and, I reckoned, was best qualified to advise me on how I should manage and invest my new-found wealth.

It had become clear that my future lay in professional cricket and, since I was not especially enjoying my Sports Science course, I decided to withdraw from my studies to focus on the game. It was not an easy decision, but I discussed the matter at length with my parents and they agreed I should focus all my energies on the game.

Northerns began their 2003/04 SuperSport Series campaign with a four-day match against Western Province, starting in Centurion on 17 October. It would be a significant day for two young cricketers, both of whom were included in the team because senior players were away on tour with the Proteas, both of whom would be making their first-class debut – one a young batsman from Warmbaths called De Villiers and the other a talented, long-haired fast bowler from Phalaborwa by the name of Dale Steyn.

Side by side, one as nervous and apprehensive as the other, we started a journey that would take us to every major cricketing stadium in the world, to unimagined places and experiences. That morning, playing for Northerns in front of a few hundred people at SuperSport Park, the limit of our ambition was to look decent.